Music entrepreneurs

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The roles of music event entrepreneurs

Planning and organisation

- Entrepreneurs are responsible for turning an idea into a real event
- This means choosing dates, locations, target audiences, and schedules
- They must also plan for things like toilets, parking, security, food stalls, and ticket sales

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Emily Eavis and her team carefully plan Glastonbury Festival each year, often booking artists and suppliers years in advance

Financial management

- They need to budget for all costs (e.g., staging, staff, artist fees, security) and find ways to earn money (e.g., ticket sales, sponsorship)
- They may also apply for funding or investment

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Smaller festivals often rely on early ticket sales ("early bird" offers) to raise money for upfront costs

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Marketing and promotion

- The entrepreneur must promote the event to attract ticket buyers and build excitement

Help me understand

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Wireless Festival uses Instagram, TikTok and YouTube ads to reach younger audiences

Artist and supplier management

- Entrepreneurs negotiate contracts with performers, stage crews, lighting providers, security companies and caterers
- They must also keep artists happy so they want to return or give good reviews

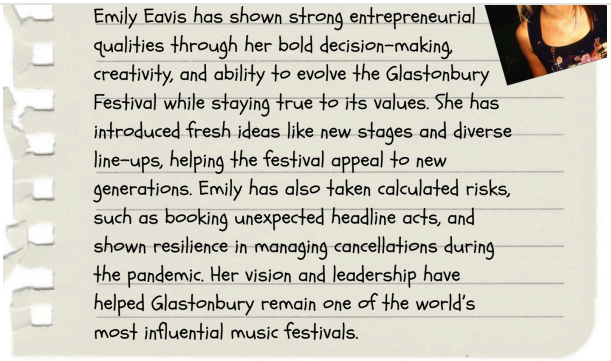
Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Melvin Benn, organiser of Reading and Leeds Festivals, works with dozens of artists and crews at once and must make sure everything runs smoothly

Logistics and operations

- This includes managing access to the site, setting up equipment, health and safety and getting the right permissions or licences from local councils
- Entrepreneurs must make sure everything works behind the scenes so the audience has a good time

Qualities of successful event entrepreneurs



Emily Eavis has shown strong entrepreneurial qualities through her bold decision-making, creativity, and ability to evolve the Glastonbury Festival while staying true to its values. She has introduced fresh ideas like new stages and diverse line-ups, helping the festival appeal to new generations. Emily has also taken calculated risks, such as booking unexpected headline acts, and shown resilience in managing cancellations during the pandemic. Her vision and leadership have helped Glastonbury remain one of the world's most influential music festivals.

Innovation

- Bringing fresh ideas to stand out from other events (e.g. new themes, stage designs, eco-friendly features)

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Glastonbury's **Arcadia Spider stage** is a 50-tonne fire-breathing structure made from recycled materials that hosts electronic music acts. It allows for aerial performances, light shows, and pyrotechnics, thus offering a unique 360-degree sensory experience

Risk-taking

- Starting a music event is financially risky - ticket sales might be low, the weather might be bad or costs might go up unexpectedly
- Entrepreneurs take these risks to chase big rewards

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: In 2023, Glastonbury's organisers took a risk by booking **Elton John** for his final UK show, unsure how a classic act would appeal to younger audiences, but it proved hugely successful.

Leadership

- They must inspire and lead a large team, from volunteers to professional contractors
- Good leadership helps everyone stay calm and motivated, especially when problems arise

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Emily Eavis showed strong leadership during the **COVID-19** pandemic by making the difficult decision to cancel Glastonbury Festival in both 2020 and 2021, prioritising public safety and financial stability

Adaptability

- Things often go wrong at events, like artist cancellations, bad weather or technical problems. Entrepreneurs must react quickly.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: In 2021, Glastonbury organisers responded to the pandemic by creating a live-streamed virtual festival, "**Live at Worthy Farm**," allowing fans to enjoy performances remotely

Network-building

- A good entrepreneur builds strong relationships with artists, suppliers, sponsors and fans
- These networks help secure better deals and grow the event year by year

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Glastonbury's organisers have built strong long-term partnerships with charities like Oxfam, Greenpeace and WaterAid

Challenges faced by music event entrepreneurs

Securing funding

- Events often cost thousands (or even millions) of dollars to run. It can be hard to get enough investment or bank loans —especially for new events
- Sponsorship is key, but hard to get without a proven track record

Example: Boomtown Festival announced financial restructuring in 2023 after higher production costs threatened their future

Booking artists

- Popular performers are expensive and booked months in advance. Smaller festivals struggle to attract big names
- If the line-up is weak, ticket sales may fall

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Latitude Festival has relied more on UK-based talent due to the rising cost of booking international artists

Effective marketing

- With so many events and festivals in the UK, it's hard to stand out
- Marketing must be creative and reach the right audience—especially on digital platforms

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Strawberries & Cream Festival grew quickly through Instagram promotions and student brand ambassadors

Contingency planning

- Entrepreneurs must have backup plans for bad weather, illnesses, tech failures, or even major emergencies (like a power cut or crowd control issue)
- Having insurance and flexible contracts helps reduce risk

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Example: Boardmasters Festival was cancelled in 2019 due to severe weather forecasts, highlighting the need for strong refund and insurance policies

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